Zitian Wang

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Education

Ph.D. Candidate in Economics, University of Virginia 2021 – 2027 (expected)

Dissertation: "Search Frictions and Welfare in a Market for Prominence: Theory and Experiment"

Committee: Charles Holt, Po-Hsuan Lin, Peter Troyan, Noah Myung

M.A. in Economics, Columbia University 2019 – 2020

B.A. in Economics and B.S. in Financial Mathematics, University of California, Los Angeles 2015 – 2019

Research Fields

Experimental Economics, Behavioral Economics, Game Theory, Industrial Organization

Job Market Paper

1. **Wang, Z.** (2026) "Search Frictions and Welfare in a Market for Prominence: Theory and Experiment" [Slides]

Working Papers

2. **Wang, Z.**, Ahmed, I., Unjitwattana, P., Xie, E.Y., Fong, M.-J. & Lin, P.-H. (2026) "Revisiting the Intra-Team Communication Method to Elicit Level-k Reasoning in Beauty Contests and 11–20 Games" **(First author)**. Revised and resubmitted to **European Economic Review**.

3. **Wang, Z.** (2025) "Coordination under Uncertainty and Noisy Communication: A Generalized Email Game" [Slides]

Conference, Seminar and Workshop Presentations

2026 Behavioral and Experimental Economics Job Market Workshop (C-BID, NYU Abu Dhabi), Economic Science Association (ESA) North American Meeting, ESA World Meeting, Behavioral and Experimental Economists of the Mid-Atlantic (BEEMA10), Northwestern–Kellogg Summer School in Economic Theory (Poster Session), UVA Theory/Experimental Student Workshop

2025 ESA North American Meeting, BEEMA9

Grants and Awards

Director of Graduate Studies Research Grant (US$2,000), University of Virginia 2026
Graduate School of Arts & Sciences Council Grant (US$500), University of Virginia 2026
Travel Grant, Conference on Field Experiments in Strategy (US$400), Duke University 2026

Professional Activities

Organizer

UVA Theory/Experimental Economics Student Workshop 2025 – 2026
UVA Theory/Experimental Economics Reading Group 2025 – 2026

Research Experience

Research assistant for Prof. Peter Troyan, University of Virginia 2026
Research assistant for Prof. Denis Nekipelov, University of Virginia 2023

Summer School Attendance

Northwestern–Kellogg Summer School in Economic Theory, Northwestern University 2026
Behavioral Game Theory Summer School, University of East Anglia 2026
Chicago School in Experimental Economics, University of Chicago 2024

Teaching

Instructor, University of Virginia

Intermediate Macroeconomics (evaluation: 4.65/5) Fall 2025, Spring 2026

Teaching Assistant, University of Virginia

Intermediate Microeconomics Spring 2024, Fall 2026
Global Financial Markets Fall 2024, Fall 2025
Economics of Risk, Uncertainty, and Information Spring 2025
Intermediate Macroeconomics Fall 2023
Principles of Macroeconomics Spring 2023
Principles of Microeconomics Fall 2022

Teaching Assistant, Columbia University

Principles of Economics Summer 2020

Skills

Programming: Python, oTree, Stata, MATLAB, LaTeX, HTML, CSS, JavaScript
Languages: Chinese (native), English (near-native)
Certificate: CFA Level I

References

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Abstracts

1. Search Frictions and Welfare in a Market for Prominence: Theory and Experiment

In online marketplaces, sellers pay platforms to make their products more visible and easier to inspect, creating a market for search prominence. I study how search friction affects the level and distribution of surplus in this market. In my model, two *ex-ante* identical sellers bid for a prominent position in a second-price auction and then simultaneously post prices. The consumer observes both prices and learns her match value for the prominent seller's product for free before deciding whether to incur a search cost to inspect the second seller's product. I derive equilibrium bids, price distributions, and search cutoffs, and test these predictions in a laboratory experiment with low and high search costs. Platform auction revenue changes little as search cost rises, despite the predicted increase. Total and consumer surplus decrease with search cost, but consumer surplus falls proportionally much less than predicted. At both search costs, consumer surplus exceeds equilibrium benchmarks, whereas sellers jointly receive only about a fifth of total surplus after paying for prominence. Further analysis of bidding, pricing, and search behavior helps explain these findings.

2. Revisiting the Intra-Team Communication Method to Elicit Level-k Reasoning in Beauty Contests and 11–20 Games

How level-0 players behave and how they are perceived by higher-level players are central questions in the literature on level-k models of boundedly rational strategic reasoning. To study these twin questions, we apply the intra-team communication method developed by Burchardi and Penczynski (2014) to identify level-0 actions and beliefs in the canonical beauty contest game and in a variant of the 11–20 game of Goeree et al. (2018), in which behavior appears inconsistent with the standard level-k model. In the beauty contest game, we replicate Burchardi and Penczynski (2014)'s finding that elicited level-0 beliefs align with observed level-0 actions. In the variant of the 11–20 game, however, elicited level-0 beliefs and observed level-0 actions diverge, and both depart from the standard level-0 assumption, suggesting a complementary explanation for the behavioral pattern documented by Goeree et al. (2018).

3. Coordination under Uncertainty and Noisy Communication: A Generalized Email Game

Which information transmission protocols improve coordination under uncertainty and noisy communication? Theory is indeterminate between an inefficient "tacit" equilibrium, where information is ignored, and an efficient "vocal" equilibrium, where players act on it. We test this in a laboratory experiment based on a generalized email game, exogenously varying the message-generation rule across three protocols. Vocal behavior rises with the incentive to take the risky action, and relative to an automatic protocol, voluntary messaging significantly improves coordination. However, a sunk cost to sending reduces vocality by inducing senders to opt out. These patterns suggest that voluntariness credibly signals players' intent to coordinate via forward induction, and that the value of cost-free signaling for equilibrium selection hinges on the alignment of interests.